

Can't vs Mustn't

CEFR B1

Lesson Pack · summary, worksheet & answer key

Quick answer

'Can't' and 'mustn't' are easy to confuse. They mean different things:

- 1 Can't — impossible, or unable (I can't lift it; that can't be true).
- 2 Mustn't — forbidden; a rule telling you not to (You mustn't run by the pool).

For deductions ('it's impossible that...'), use 'can't', never 'mustn't': He can't have finished already.

At a glance

	Can't	Mustn't
Meaning	impossible / unable / not allowed	forbidden (a strong rule)
Used for guesses?	yes (negative deduction)	no
Example	It can't be true.	You mustn't be late.

Learning objectives

- Can distinguish 'can't' (impossibility/inability) from 'mustn't' (prohibition) (CEFR B1).
- Can use 'can't' for negative deductions.
- Can avoid using 'mustn't' for guesses.

Practice worksheet

Circle the correct option. Can't vs Mustn't · CEFR B1

Name: _____

Date: _____

1. This box is far too heavy — I ____ lift it.

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|------------------|-------------|
| A. can't | B. mustn't |
| C. don't have to | D. can't to |

2. During the test, you ____ look at your neighbour's answers.

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|------------------|---------------|
| A. can't | B. mustn't |
| C. don't have to | D. mustn't to |

3. That ____ be Sara — she's in Australia right now.

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|------------------|-----------------|
| A. mustn't | B. can't |
| C. don't have to | D. doesn't must |

4. You ____ touch the paintings in the museum.

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|------------------|----------------|
| A. can't | B. mustn't |
| C. don't have to | D. aren't able |

5. He ____ have finished the whole book already — he only started today!

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|--------------------|-----------------|
| A. can't | B. mustn't |
| C. doesn't have to | D. mustn't have |

6. I'm sorry, I ____ come to your party — I'll be away.

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|------------------|-------------|
| A. can't | B. mustn't |
| C. don't have to | D. can't to |

7. We ____ forget to send the invoice, or we won't get paid.

- | | |
|------------------|-------------------|
| A. can't | B. mustn't |
| C. don't have to | D. aren't able to |

8. Correct this: 'That mustn't be the right answer.'

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|--|---|
| A. That can't be the right answer. | B. That mustn't to be the right answer. |
| C. That doesn't have to be the right answer. | D. The sentence is already correct. |

9. Which sentence expresses a PROHIBITION?

- | | |
|-----------------------------|----------------------------------|
| A. You can't be serious. | B. You mustn't feed the animals. |
| C. I can't reach the shelf. | D. That can't be right. |

10. The door's locked from inside, so she ____ have gone out this way.

- | | |
|--------------------|-----------------|
| A. can't | B. mustn't |
| C. doesn't have to | D. mustn't have |

Answer key

Correct answers with explanations · for the teacher

1. **A. can't** — Inability takes 'can't': 'I can't lift it'.
2. **B. mustn't** — A firm prohibition takes 'mustn't': 'You mustn't look at their answers'.
3. **B. can't** — A negative deduction takes 'can't': 'That can't be Sara'.
4. **B. mustn't** — A firm rule takes 'mustn't': 'You mustn't touch the paintings'.
5. **A. can't** — Impossibility about the past takes 'can't have': 'He can't have finished'.
6. **A. can't** — Being unable due to circumstances takes 'can't': 'I can't come'.
7. **B. mustn't** — A strong 'don't' takes 'mustn't': 'We mustn't forget to send the invoice'.
8. **A. That can't be the right answer.** — A negative deduction takes 'can't': 'That can't be the right answer'.
9. **B. You mustn't feed the animals.** — 'You mustn't feed the animals' forbids the action.
10. **A. can't** — Impossibility takes 'can't have': 'she can't have gone out this way'.